



MODULE 8

Broker Vetting, Fraud & Negotiation

**Is this broker real? Is this rate right?
Answer both before you book.**

Freight fraud patterns, double brokering, impersonation, twelve red flags, the seven-step broker check, the \$75,000 broker security rule, document checks at pickup, what to do when something is wrong, the dispatcher's legal lines, and a full negotiation method with scripts.

7

checks for every new broker

12

red flags

6

brokers to vet in practice

4

negotiation role-plays

How to use this module

Module 6 found the loads. Module 7 priced them. Now two jobs stand between you and a signed rate con: **make sure the broker is real and will pay**, and **get the rate the truck needs**.

Truck 12's numbers you'll use

From Module 7 (practice)

Break-even **\$2.59** per total mile · target **\$2.70** · ask = target × total miles · walk-away = break-even × total miles, unless the next leg justifies less · the carrier (Mike) makes the final call.

Study rhythm (about 6 hours)

- **Session 1 (1.5 h):** fraud patterns, impersonation, red flags.
- **Session 2 (1.5 h):** broker check, FMCSA records, \$75,000 rule, pickup check.
- **Session 3 (1.5 h):** response steps, legal lines, negotiation method.
- **Session 4 (1.5 h):** vet six brokers, drill 10, role-play prep.



Role-play with Claude

Page 19 has four negotiation scenarios. When you're ready, ask me to play the broker. I'll push back like a real one, and afterwards I'll show you where you left money on the table.

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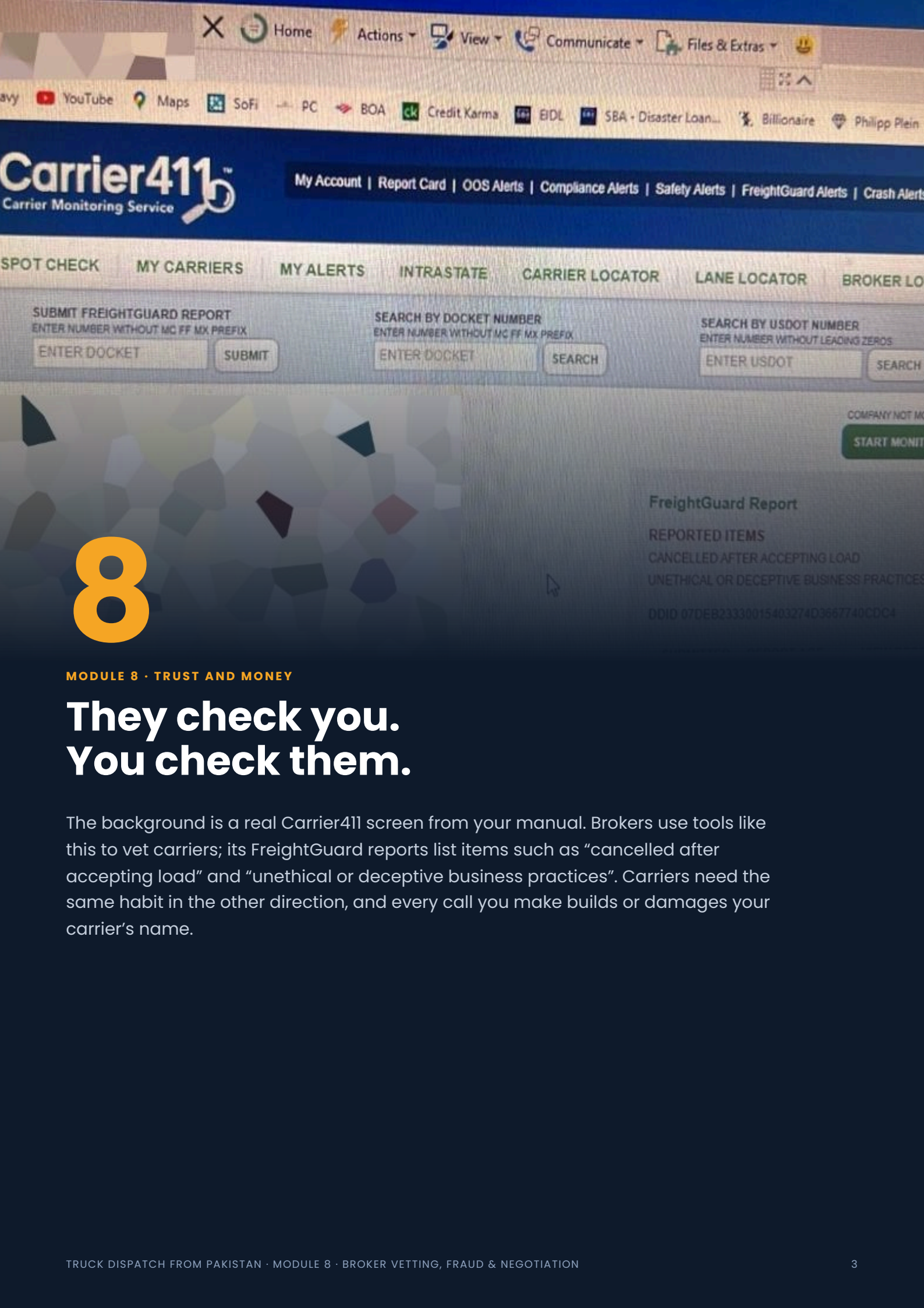
Not legal advice

This module explains FMCSA rules and common practice so you can spot problems. When money or liability is at stake, the carrier should talk to its attorney, insurer or factor.



Why this matters more for you

Many brokers are cautious about offshore dispatchers because some fraud comes from overseas. Your best defence is being **transparent, verifiable and precise** on every call.



8

MODULE 8 · TRUST AND MONEY

They check you. You check them.

The background is a real Carrier411 screen from your manual. Brokers use tools like this to vet carriers; its FreightGuard reports list items such as “cancelled after accepting load” and “unethical or deceptive business practices”. Carriers need the same habit in the other direction, and every call you make builds or damages your carrier’s name.

Freight fraud: what you're up against

Why brokers and shippers are nervous

Verisk CargoNet, 2025 U.S. and Canada supply-chain crime analysis.

\$725M

estimated cargo theft losses in 2025

+60% vs 2024

2,646

confirmed cargo theft incidents

+18% vs 2024

\$273,990

average value per theft

+36%

+47%

food & beverage thefts

meat, seafood, nuts

Theft by deception: Verisk CargoNet expects more schemes that exploit how loads are tendered to carriers: fake carriers and brokers, stolen identities, fictitious pickups.

Your part: vet every new broker, keep carrier documents private, confirm pickups with the broker on an official number, and never change a delivery address on a phone call alone.

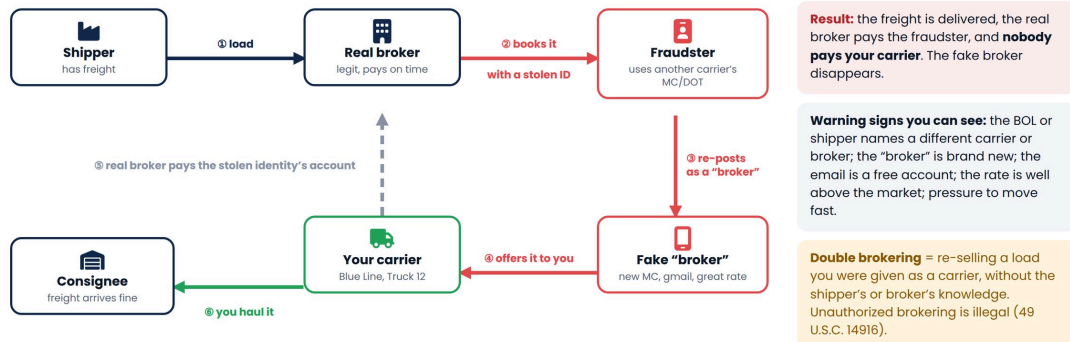
Six schemes that hit carriers and dispatchers

Scheme	How it works	How the carrier loses
Double brokering	A load is re-sold, often by someone using a stolen carrier or broker identity	Hauls it and never gets paid
Broker impersonation	Fake emails and phones copy a real broker's name	Unpaid load, stolen packet, or worse
Carrier identity theft	Criminals use <i>your</i> carrier's MC/DOT to book loads and steal freight	Claims, police calls, blocked by brokers
Fictitious pickup	A fake carrier picks up real freight and disappears	Brokers tighten rules; honest carriers get more checks
Phishing	"Load details" links steal board, email or factoring logins	Account takeover, diverted payments
Payment diversion	Fake NOA or bank-change letters redirect the broker's payment	The money goes to the thief

How a “normal” load goes unpaid

How double brokering hurts the carrier

One common pattern, simplified. Every step can look normal from where you sit.



Why it works

Everyone in the chain sees something normal: a shipper hands over freight, a truck shows up, the load delivers. The only one who notices is the carrier, weeks later, when the invoice bounces between companies that don't know each other.

The fix is upstream: **vet the broker before booking** (Lesson 8.2) and **check the BOL at pickup** (page 11).



Correction: “Re-brokering is fine if everyone gets paid”

If you are a carrier (or its dispatcher), you haul the loads you accept. Handing a load to another carrier is brokering. Without broker registration and the \$75,000 security it is unlawful, whether or not everyone gets paid.



One test

If the shipper's paperwork, the broker on your rate con and the company that calls you don't all line up, stop and verify before the truck moves.

Protect your carrier's identity

Habit	Why
Lock the FMCSA login	The owner keeps the FMCSA/Motus login private with multi-factor authentication; thieves change contact details to hijack authority
One official email and phone	Keep them current on the FMCSA record and tell brokers to trust only those
Use identity platforms	Setup platforms such as Highway let brokers confirm they are dealing with the real carrier
Watch for strange calls	A broker asking about a load you never booked = possible identity theft. Tell the carrier the same day
Don't post documents publicly	MC certificate, COI and W-9 go only to verified brokers, never to social media groups

Real broker or copy?

Spot the impersonator

Fraudsters copy real brokers' names and signatures. The details give them away. Names, domains and numbers are fictional.

Real broker (practice)

From: mark.hill@lakeshorelogistics.com

Subject: Load LL-448210 Chicago → Charlotte

Hi Jawad, load is yours at \$2,050. Please send your carrier packet and sign the attached rate con ASAP.

Mark Hill · Carrier Sales · Lakeshore Logistics

Office (312) 555-0142 · same as website and FMCSA record

- ✓ Domain matches the company website exactly
- ✓ Phone matches the website and the FMCSA/SAFER record
- ✓ Rate con is from the broker's own system or setup platform
- ✓ Asks you to complete setup on its known platform

Impersonator (practice)

From: mark.hill@lakeshore-logistics-llc.com

Subject: Load LL-448210 Chicago → Charlotte

Hi Jawad, load is yours at \$2,050. Please send your carrier packet and sign the attached rate con ASAP.

Mark Hill · Carrier Sales · Lakeshore Logistics

Cell (773) 555-0199 · "call me on this number only"

- ✗ Extra words and a hyphen in the domain
- ✗ Different phone, "cell only", texts instead of calls
- ✗ Asks for your packet by email, skips the setup platform
- ✗ Wants quick pay to a new bank account or asks for your login codes

The fix is always the same: find the broker's number **yourself** (company website, FMCSA/SAFER record, load-board profile), call it, and ask for the person by name. Never trust contact details that only exist inside the suspicious message.

Protect your own accounts

- Turn on **multi-factor authentication** for email, load boards and the factoring portal.
- Never open "rate con" or "load details" links from unknown senders. Log in to the platform yourself.
- Never share login codes, even with someone claiming to be "support".
- Send carrier documents only through setup platforms or verified addresses.



FMCSA's advice

FMCSA says to confirm broker and carrier phone numbers using SAFER, remember that "even insurance certificates can be fraudulent," and stop if someone asks you to misrepresent your company, proposes blind loads, offers unusually high rates or pressures a quick deal.



Your carrier can be impersonated too

If a broker calls asking about a load you never booked, someone may be using Blue Line's MC. Tell Mike immediately. Carriers can warn brokers through setup platforms and report it to FMCSA.

Twelve red flags

Twelve red flags

One flag = slow down and verify. Two or more = stop and tell the carrier. Partly from FMCSA's fraud guidance.



Rate far above the market
Bait to rush you past checks



Brand-new authority
Weeks old, no history, no reviews



Free email or lookalike domain
gmail, hyphens, extra words



Cell-only, text-only contact
Won't take a call on the office line



Pressure to book now
"Another carrier is waiting"



Asks you to hide your identity
"Blind" load, use another name
(FMCSA red flag)



New bank / quick-pay details
Change of payment info by email



Asks for logins or codes
Load-board, ELD, email or factoring codes



Pickup changes after booking
New address, "meet at a truck stop"



Names don't match
Rate con, BOL, SAFER, emails



Odd equipment asks
Day cab for a multi-day run; no tracking



Asks you to pay
Fees, deposits, "load purchase"

The "two flags" rule

One flag has innocent explanations: a new broker has to start somewhere, and a hot load can pay well. **Two or more flags together**, like brand-new authority with a gmail address and a rate \$300 above the rest, is the classic fraud pattern. Stop and tell the carrier.

Flags	Action
0	Normal checks, book
1	Verify that point on an official channel
2+	Stop · tell the carrier · probably pass



Brokers check carriers, too

Brokers use setup platforms and monitoring services (like the Carrier411 screen on page 3) to vet carriers, looking at authority age, insurance, safety, and reports such as "cancelled after accepting load". Every cancellation you cause can follow your carrier.



Stay polite

"I just need to verify a couple of things before we book" is normal business. Real brokers respect it. Fraudsters push back or disappear.

Innocent explanation or fraud pattern?

Flag	Could be innocent	Fraud pattern
High rate	Late load, hard pickup, holiday, tight market; the broker explains why	High rate + new broker + pressure; no clear reason
New authority	New office of an experienced team; normal contacts, platform setup	New + free email + cell only + unusual payment instructions
Pickup change	Broker updates the rate con and the shipper confirms	Change by phone only; "meet at a truck stop"; new consignee
New bank details	Carrier switched factors, with an NOA release letter	Email-only change, urgent, different company name on the account

Vetting a broker in seven steps

Vetting a broker: the seven checks

Carrier-side due diligence. Official records first, then money, then paperwork.

- 1  **Authority** SAFER: entity type **BROKER**, broker authority **active**. A carrier-only MC cannot legally broker.
- 2  **\$75,000 security** L&I: a **BMC-84** bond or **BMC-85** trust fund on file, not cancelled.
- 3  **Contact match** Phone and email match the website and FMCSA record. Call back on a number **you** found.
- 4  **Age & history** Authority age, name changes, reviews, board profile. Brand-new + high rate = slow down.
- 5  **Credit & pay** Credit score, days to pay, factor's credit check. Will the factor buy this invoice?
- 6  **Tools** Highway for Carriers (free), load-board broker profile, factor, your own notes.
- 7  **Rate con check** Name, MC, address and contact on the rate con match everything above.

Five minutes, before the rate con. Do steps 1–3 for every new broker. Do all seven when the broker is new to you, the rate is unusually high, or anything feels rushed.

Keep a list. Once a broker passes, save the MC, official phone, email domain and your notes. Next time, check only what can change: authority, bond, credit.

Stop if any of steps 1–3 fails. Tell the carrier; don't negotiate your way past a red flag.

Where each check happens

Check	Where
1–2 Authority, bond	FMCSA SAFER and L&I (free, public)
3 Contact	Broker's website, SAFER, board profile
4 History	SAFER/L&I dates, board reviews, your notes
5 Credit	DAT credit score and days to pay, factor's check
6 Tools	Highway for Carriers (free), board profile
7 Rate con	The document itself, against all of the above



Highway for Carriers

Launched in March 2025 and free for carriers. Search a broker by name, MC or DOT to confirm authority, activity and credit standing, and see potential fraud risks. Carriers also use it for broker setups (Module 5).



Save what you learn

Keep a simple broker list: name, MC, official phone, email domain, pay speed, notes. It turns 5 minutes into 30 seconds next time.

Reading a broker's record

Reading a broker's FMCSA record

Recreated for this course with a fictional company. Layouts on the live sites may differ; the fields are what matter.

Company Snapshot (recreated) · PRACTICE BROKER LLC	
Entity Type	BROKER
USDOT Status	ACTIVE
Legal Name	PRACTICE BROKER LLC
Physical Address	100 EXAMPLE AVE, CHICAGO, IL
Phone	(312) 555-0142
MC/MX/FF Number(s)	MC-XXXXXX
Operating Authority Status	AUTHORIZED FOR Broker Property
Power Units / Drivers	0 / 0

Licensing & Insurance (recreated)			
Authority	Status	Since	
Broker	ACTIVE	2011	
Common / Contract	NONE	—	
Form	Type	Coverage	Cancelled
BMC-84	SURETY	\$75,000	—
BOC-3 (process agent): on file			

Broker check = two lookups. SAFER: is it a **broker** with authority? L&I: is there a **BMC-84** or **BMC-85** for \$75,000 with no cancellation date?

Brokers have no trucks. 0 power units is normal for a broker. A company that shows only carrier authority and offers you loads is brokering without authority.

Also check: phone and address against the rate con and emails. A match isn't proof, but a mismatch is a stop sign.

Carrier record vs broker record

Field	Carrier (Module 5)	Broker
Entity type	CARRIER	BROKER
Authority	Motor carrier of property	Broker of property
Money filing	BIPD insurance (\$750,000+)	BMC-84 bond or BMC-85 trust (\$75,000)
Power units	1 or more	Usually 0



Some companies are both

A company can hold carrier and broker authority. Check which one applies to **this load**: the rate con should name it as broker, and the broker authority must be active.



Motus changes (Module 5)

FMCSA is moving registration into Motus and adding USDOT status suffixes for new registrants. Broker MC numbers still appear on existing records. Always use the live FMCSA site.

Broker security and unpaid loads

The \$75,000 broker security rule

FMCSA process summarized from its Educational and Compliance Guide. Business days, not calendar days.



If a broker doesn't pay: the carrier's escalation ladder

#	Step	What to do
1	Check the terms	Rate con payment terms (for example 30 days), quick-pay option, documents required (signed BOL/POD, invoice)
2	Resend and confirm	Resend invoice and POD to the address on the rate con; ask for the expected pay date in writing
3	Factor collections	If the carrier factors, the factor chases payment; non-recourse terms may cover credit failures
4	Bond claim	Carrier files a claim against the broker's BMC-84 surety or BMC-85 trust (provider listed on L&I)
5	Report	FMCSA National Consumer Complaint Database; board reviews and credit reports
6	Legal	Carrier's attorney or a collections agency for larger amounts

You support the carrier with documents and dates. The carrier (or its factor) owns the claim.

Real BOL and rate con for load #12354 from your OMNITECH manual. Markers added for this course.

Field	Rate con	BOL	
Shipper / pickup	Green Bay Packaging, Lebanon OH	Green Bay Packaging, Lebanon OH	✓
Consignee	Tracco, Owensboro KY	Tracco LLC, Owensboro KY	✓
Commodity	Skidded paper	Printed corrugated boxes (paper)	✓
Units	10	10	✓
Weight	2,000 lb	5,729 lb	✗
Carrier named	Your carrier	(blank)	?

Fraud check at pickup: if the BOL or the shipper names a **different carrier or broker** than your rate con, stop. Call the broker on its official number before the truck moves.

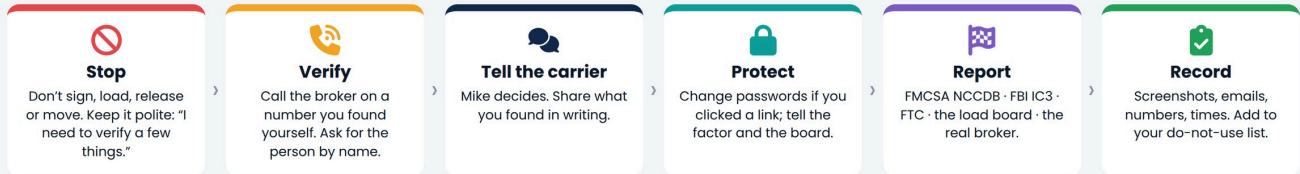
"Carlos, please don't leave yet. The BOL shows 5,729 pounds and our rate con says 2,000. I'm calling the broker now and will call you back in five minutes."

Item	Check against	If different
Shipper name and address	Rate con pickup	Stop; call the broker
Carrier and broker the shipper expects	Your carrier and your broker	Stop: possible double brokering
Pieces, weight, commodity	Rate con	Call the broker; get the update in writing
Seal number	Write it on the BOL; photo	Note any broken or missing seal
Delivery address	Rate con consignee	Never change it on a phone call alone

The six-step response

Something is wrong: what to do

Six steps, in order. Speed matters, but verification matters more.



FMCSA's reporting list: National Consumer Complaint Database (nccdb.fmcsa.dot.gov), FMCSA Contact Center 1-800-832-5660, FTC (reportfraud.ftc.gov), FBI IC3 (ic3.gov) or the state attorney general, DOT Inspector General hotline.

If the truck is already loaded and you discover a mismatch: don't deliver to a new address. Call the real broker and shipper on official numbers and follow their instructions with the carrier.

Example: the lookalike email

A "Lakeshore Logistics" rep emails from **lakeshore-logistics-llc.com** asking for your packet. You **stop**, **verify** by calling Lakeshore's number from its website (they have no such rep), **tell Mike**, **protect** (no documents were sent), **report** to Lakeshore, the load board and FMCSA, and **record** the domain on your do-not-use list.



Don't play detective

Don't confront, threaten or "trap" a suspected fraudster. Stop the transaction, protect the carrier, and report to the proper channels.



Write it down immediately

Times, numbers, emails, screenshots. Reports and claims go faster with evidence, and memory fades by the next shift.

Who to tell, and when

Who	When
The carrier (Mike)	Always, first, in writing
The real broker	Someone is impersonating them, or their load is being re-sold
The load board	Fake postings, fake accounts, phishing through the board
The factor	Payment redirection, fake NOA, suspicious broker credit
FMCSA NCCDB	Identity theft, unauthorized brokering, broker non-payment
FBI IC3 / FTC / police	Money lost, cargo stolen, cyber fraud (the carrier files; you supply evidence)

Stay on the carrier's side

The dispatcher's legal lines

Carrier-side dispatch works only when you stay clearly on the carrier's side.

Always

- ✓ Say who you are: "Jawad, dispatcher for Blue Line Transport"
- ✓ Book only for the carrier you work for, with its written permission
- ✓ Get paid only by the carrier (your agreement)
- ✓ Use your own login or seat, set up by the carrier
- ✓ Send documents only through verified channels
- ✓ Report fraud; keep notes of every call

Never

- ✗ Pretend to be the owner or use a fake American name to deceive
- ✗ Give a load to another carrier: that is brokering
- ✗ Take money from brokers or shippers for loads
- ✗ Share or borrow load-board logins
- ✗ Change the carrier name on documents, or run "blind" loads you're asked to hide
- ✗ Book below the carrier's minimum without asking

Why it matters: brokering without FMCSA broker registration and the \$75,000 security is unlawful: civil penalties up to \$10,000 per violation under 49 U.S.C. 14916, and officers can be personally liable. Brokers and carriers are also wary of offshore dispatch because of fraud, so transparency is how you build trust.

How to introduce yourself honestly

"Hi, this is Jawad, dispatcher for Blue Line Transport, MC 1298456." If asked where you are: **"I work remotely for Blue Line. Mike, the owner, can be reached at the number on our FMCSA record."**

Being honest about your role costs you nothing with good brokers and protects your carrier if anyone checks.



The law in one line

A person may provide interstate brokerage only if registered as a broker with FMCSA and meeting the financial security requirement (49 U.S.C. 14916). Penalties can reach \$10,000 per violation, and officers and principals can be personally liable.



Correction: "Dispatchers can share loads between their carriers"

If you dispatch for two carriers and move a load booked by one to the other, you are acting as a broker. Each carrier books and hauls its own loads.

Prepare before you dial

Prepare before you dial: the 60-second prep card

Six things you know before the broker says a number. Worked for Load 2.



Break-even · target

\$2.59 · \$2.70 per total mile → \$1,883 · \$1,963 for 727 mi



Market range

Rate tool / similar posts: \$1,752–\$2,038 (practice)



Your alternatives

Load 1 at \$2,050; Load 8 Thursday; post the truck



What the broker needs

Wednesday pickup, 53' van, on-time delivery Thursday



Your leverage

Rate below market, same-day pickup, few trucks near Bolingbrook this morning



Non-rate asks

Detention after 2 h, lumper paid by broker, quick pay terms

Your alternatives are your power. If you have two other workable loads, you can say no calmly. If you have nothing, you negotiate scared, and brokers can hear it.

Five principles

1. **Facts first, rate second.** Confirm the load details before you talk money (drill 8).
2. **Know your numbers.** Target, walk-away, market range. Say them in dollars.
3. **Anchor with a reason.** Your first number sets the range. Tie it to miles, market or timing.
4. **Move in shrinking steps.** Big first step, smaller after. It signals you are near your limit.
5. **Be ready to walk.** Politely, with an open door: "If it changes, call me."



Correction: "Always accept the posted rate to win loads"

Posted rates are often an opening number. Brokers expect carriers to counter, and many lanes have room. Accepting every first offer trains brokers to lowball your carrier.



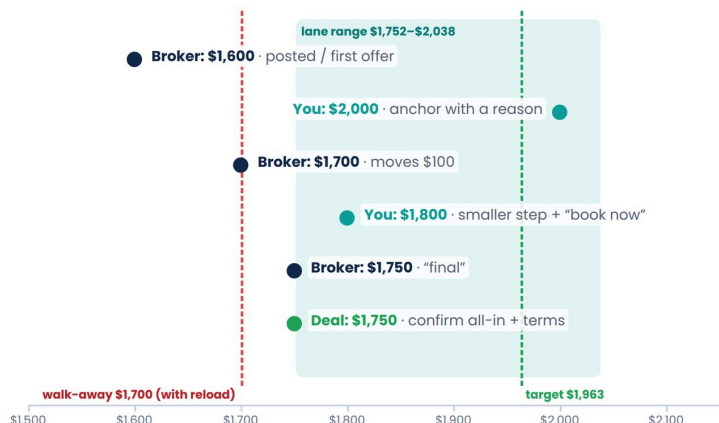
Carrier-side, not personal

You aren't fighting the broker. You both want the load covered. Your job is to get a fair price for your carrier's truck, and a respectful tone gets better rates over time.

Load 2, step by step

A negotiation, step by step

Practice numbers. The green band is the lane's recent range, the dashed lines are your target and walk-away.



Load 2 · Bolingbrook → Atlanta · 715 mi + 12 DH

Practice lane range (per loaded mile): \$2.45–\$2.85 → \$1,752–\$2,038. The first offer (\$1,600 = \$2.24) is **below the low end**: you have a reason to push.

Anchor high, with a reason. \$2,000 is inside the range and near target. Each step you make gets smaller: \$2,000 → \$1,800 → accept \$1,750.

Your walk-away comes from Module 7. With the \$1,700 Atlanta reload, \$1,750 makes the two-load trip \$2.62. Without a reload, walk away below break-even: $727 \times \$2.59 = \$1,883$.

Say it out loud · drill 10: the negotiation

Who	Line
You	“Hi, this is Jawad with Blue Line Transport, MC 1298456, calling about your Bolingbrook to Atlanta load for Wednesday. Is it still available?”
Broker	“Yes, it is.”
You	“Great. What’s the commodity and weight, and what are the pickup and delivery appointments?”
Broker	“Paper products, 38,500 pounds. Pickup Wednesday 9 to 11, delivery Thursday 1 PM.”
You	“Okay. What are you paying on it?”
Broker	“\$1,600.”
You	“For 727 miles with a same-day pickup I need \$2,000. This lane has been running around \$2.60 a mile.” <i>(Then stop talking.)</i>
Broker	“I can go \$1,700.”
You	“Meet me at \$1,800 and I’ll book it now.”
Broker	“\$1,750 is the best I can do.”
You	“Let me confirm with my carrier. I’ll call you back in five minutes.”

Broker lines and calm answers

Five broker lines and calm answers

Polite, specific, always with a number or a next step. Adapt the numbers to your own load.

Broker

"That's all I've got on it."

You

"I understand. The lane is running about \$2.60 a mile this week. Can you check with your team if there's room to \$1,900?"

Broker

"I have trucks all over this."

You

"Then you'll cover it fast. If it's still open at 11, call me. I can do \$1,850 and pick up today."

Broker

"What's your best rate?"

You

"For 727 miles with a same-day pickup, I need \$2,000." (Say a number. Then stop talking.)

Broker

"Can you do \$1,700 if I add a second stop?"

You

"A stop adds time. \$1,700 plus \$100 for the stop, and detention after two hours."

Broker

"Book it now or I give it away."

You

"I need two minutes to confirm with my carrier. I'll call you back at 9:42."

Things to trade besides the rate

Ask	Why it's worth money
Detention terms	Paid waiting after a set free time (Module 10)
Lumper paid by broker	Unloading fees can be \$100+
Quick pay terms	Cash faster, lower or no factoring fee
Extra stop pay	Each stop costs time and hours
Later pickup / wider window	Lets the truck finish or rest properly
Backhaul or next load	Solves the reload problem (Module 7)



Silence is a tool

After you say your number, stop. The first person to fill the silence usually moves. Count to five in your head.



Never bluff about facts

Don't invent another offer, a fake appointment or a false truck location. Brokers talk to each other, and one lie costs your carrier more than any single load.

Closing the deal cleanly

Before you say “send the rate con”

1. **Total, all-in:** “So that’s \$1,750 all-in, including fuel?”
2. **Appointments:** pickup and delivery times, FCFS or appointment, time zone.
3. **Details:** commodity, weight, pieces, equipment, tracking app.
4. **Accessorials:** detention after how many hours and at what rate, lumper, TONU.
5. **Payment:** terms, quick pay, where to send invoices.
6. **Carrier approval:** Mike says yes (or the load is within his written limits).
7. **Setup:** broker has (or will get) the packet through its platform.



The close

“Mike confirmed. We’ll take it at \$1,750 all-in. Detention after two hours, and lumper covered by you, correct? Please send the rate confirmation to our dispatch email and the setup link if you need one. Thank you!”



When the rate con arrives

Read it line by line **before** anyone signs: rate, all-in, dates, addresses, commodity, weight, accessorials, deductions, payment terms, broker name and MC (Module 9 goes deeper). If anything differs from the call, ask for a corrected rate con.



Walking away well

“I understand. I can’t do it under \$1,850 today. If it’s still open later, call me at this number.” Many loads come back an hour later at your price.

Five negotiation mistakes

Mistake	Instead
Asking “what’s your best?” then accepting it	Counter with your number and a reason
Negotiating per mile on loaded miles	Talk totals; you know your total-mile math
Splitting the difference too early	Shrinking steps: \$2,000 → \$1,800 → final
Agreeing, then “forgetting” detention and lumper	Confirm accessorials before the rate con
Booking before the carrier approves	“Let me confirm with my carrier: five minutes.”

PRACTICE

Vet six brokers

For each broker decide: **PASS** **CAUTION** **STOP**, and write the flag(s) and your next action. All names, domains and details are fictional.

#	Broker · load	What your checks show	Decision · flags · next action
A	Lakeshore Logistics Load 1 · \$2,050	Broker authority active since 2011 · BMC-84 \$75,000, no cancellation · email @lakeshorelogistics.com matches website · office phone matches website and SAFER · CS 96, DTP 28	
B	Prime Direct Freight LLC Load 10 · \$2,300	Broker authority granted 3 weeks ago · BMC-84 on file · email primedirectfreight@gmail.com · calls from a cell · rate ~\$300 above similar loads · “book in 5 minutes, email me your packet”	
C	Caller “Dan” from Peachtree Freight Load 2 · \$1,600	Peachtree’s SAFER record is fine · Dan emails from @peachtree-freight-llc.com (website: peachtreefreight.com) · his phone differs from the website · you call the official number: no Dan works there	
D	Quickline Transport Brokers Load 6 · no rate	Broker authority active 6 years · BMC-84 \$75,000 · email and phone match · CS 71, DTP 58 · the factor approves the broker but with a credit limit and no quick pay	
E	Midwest Freight Partners Load 8 · \$1,950	SAFER entity type CARRIER only · common carrier authority, 2 power units · no broker authority · offering you loads from “our customers”	
F	Harbor Point Logistics Load 7 · \$2,700	Broker authority active 4 years · L&I shows BMC-84 with a cancellation effective in 10 days · everything else matches · CS 90, DTP 30	

Bonus: for broker C, write the exact words you’d use when calling Peachtree’s official number, and the message you’d send Mike afterwards.

Quick quiz: flag or fine?

#	Situation	Flag / fine?
1	A broker with 10 years of authority pays \$150 over the lane average for a same-day pickup, and says why	
2	A broker asks you to tell the shipper you are “ABC Transport” instead of Blue Line	
3	After booking, the broker texts a new delivery address and asks the driver to go straight there	
4	A broker asks for your carrier packet through its Highway setup link	
5	An email with “Rate con attached, click to view” comes from an address you don’t know	
6	The factor says it won’t buy invoices from this broker	

Answers: 1 fine (explained) · 2 flag: misrepresenting identity · 3 flag: verify with the broker’s official number and a corrected rate con · 4 fine · 5 flag: phishing risk · 6 flag: credit risk, tell Mike

Four negotiation role-plays

Prepare each with the prep card (page 14): numbers, alternatives, leverage, non-rate asks. Then practise out loud, and when ready, ask Claude to play the broker.

Role-play 1 Posted load, room to push

Load 1 · Chicago → Charlotte · posted \$2,050 · 760 loaded + 40 DH · practice lane range \$2.45–\$2.85 per loaded mile (\$1,862–\$2,166)

Your numbers: Target \$2,160 · walk-away \$2,072 · anchor about \$2,250

Role-play 2 Broker calls on your posted truck

Joliet → Nashville · 470 loaded + 15 DH · broker offers \$1,150 (\$2.37 per total mile) · pickup today 2 PM

Your numbers: Target \$1,310 (485 × \$2.70) · ask \$1,400 · walk-away \$1,256

Role-play 3 Rich rate, weak destination

Load 7 · Kankakee → Jacksonville · \$2,700 · 1,085 total mi · reloads out of Jacksonville are thin and cheap

Your numbers: Ask \$2,930+ or pass · use the reload problem as your reason

Role-play 4 Slow facility, protect the driver

A load you like at a fair rate, but the shipper is known for 4-hour waits

Your numbers: Keep the rate · negotiate detention after 2 h in writing (practice: \$50/h) and a later pickup window



How to start a role-play with me

Type: **“Role-play 2. You’re the broker. I’m Jawad from Blue Line.”** I’ll stay in character, push back realistically, and give you a score and feedback at the end.



Score yourself

Facts before rate? A number with a reason? Shrinking steps? Stayed at or above walk-away? Confirmed all-in and accessorials? Polite close either way?

Module 8 check

1. What is double brokering, and why does the carrier often end up unpaid?
2. Name four of the twelve red flags.
3. Which two FMCSA lookups confirm a broker's authority and financial security? Which forms should you see?
4. Under the rule in force since 16 January 2026, what happens when a broker's security drops below \$75,000?
5. Someone emails claiming to work for a broker you know. How do you verify them?
6. The BOL at pickup names a different carrier than yours. What do you tell the driver, and what do you do?
7. Name three places FMCSA says to report freight fraud.
8. Why can't a dispatcher move a load from one of their carriers to another?
9. What is a walk-away number, and where does it come from?
10. What does "anchor with a reason" mean? Give an example sentence.
11. Name three things you can negotiate besides the rate.
12. What must you confirm before asking for the rate confirmation?

Skills self-check

Skill	Can do	Need practice
Run the seven broker checks in under 5 minutes	☐	☐
Read a broker's SAFER and L&I record (authority, BMC-84/85)	☐	☐
Spot an impersonator email and verify through official channels	☐	☐
Compare BOL and rate con at pickup	☐	☐
Follow the six-step response when something is wrong	☐	☐
Negotiate with target, walk-away and a reasoned anchor (drill 10)	☐	☐
Close cleanly: all-in, accessorial, terms, carrier approval	☐	☐

Answers: vet six brokers

#	Decision	Flags and next action
A	PASS	No flags. Complete setup on its platform, negotiate (target \$2,160), read the rate con.
B	STOP	Four flags: 3-week-old authority, free email, cell only, rate well above market, plus pressure and packet by email. Tell Mike, pass, note it on your list.
C	STOP	Impersonation: lookalike domain, wrong phone, official office has no "Dan". Send nothing. Tell Peachtree, Mike and the board; report to FMCSA NCCDB. If you want the real load, book it through Peachtree's official contact.
D	CAUTION	Legitimate but slow payer (CS 71, DTP 58) with a factor limit. Ask Mike if he accepts slower pay; ask for quick-pay terms; stay under the factor limit.
E	STOP	No broker authority: brokering without authority, and a double-brokering risk. Decline politely.
F	CAUTION	Bond cancellation pending (BMC-36). Ask the broker if a replacement bond is filed; recheck L&I. If not, a load paying in 30 days is risky: pass or ask for quick pay.

Bonus "Hi, this is Jawad, dispatcher for Blue Line Transport. I'm verifying a contact: someone named Dan emailed from peachtree-freight-llc.com about your Bolingbrook-Atlanta load. Does Dan work with you, and is that your domain?" Then to Mike: "Stopped a fake Peachtree contact (lookalike domain, no such employee). Sent nothing. Reported to Peachtree and the board. Real load still available through their office."

RP 3 $\$2,700 \div 1,085 = \2.49 , 10¢ under break-even, into a weak reload market. Ask \$2,930 (1,085 × \$2.70) with the reason "Jacksonville reloads are thin; I'll likely deadhead out." If the broker won't pass about \$2,810 (break-even), pass unless Mike wants the lane.

RP 2 Walk-away check: $485 \times \$2.59 = \$1,256$. Target $485 \times \$2.70 = \$1,310$ (rounded). Anchor near \$1,400; \$1,150 would lose money.

RP 1 Ask \$2,250 (\$2.96 per loaded mile, just above the range, leaving room to come down); accept ≥ \$2,160 or check with Mike between \$2,072 and \$2,160.

RP 4 Keep the rate; ask for "detention after 2 hours at \$50 an hour, on the rate con" and a pickup window that fits Carlos's hours. Confirm how to report arrival times (in/out on the BOL, tracking app). Module 10 covers detention claims.

Answers: module check

- 1** Re-selling a load you took as a carrier, often via stolen identities. The real broker pays whoever it contracted with (the fraudster), who never pays your carrier.
- 2** Any four: rate far above market; brand-new authority; free or lookalike email; cell-only; pressure; hide your identity; new bank details; asks for logins; pickup changes; names don't match; odd equipment; asks you to pay.
- 3** SAFER (entity type BROKER, broker authority active) and L&I (BMC-84 surety bond or BMC-85 trust fund, \$75,000, no cancellation).
- 4** The provider notifies FMCSA; FMCSA notifies the broker, who has 7 business days to restore it or show an error; otherwise its authority is suspended.
- 5** Find the broker's phone yourself (website, SAFER, board profile), call, and ask for the person by name. Compare the email domain with the website.
- 6** "Don't leave yet." Call the broker on its official number (and the shipper if needed), tell Mike, and move only when it's resolved in writing.
- 7** FMCSA NCCDB (nccdb.fmcsa.dot.gov), FMCSA Contact Center 1-800-832-5660, FTC, FBI IC3 or state attorney general, DOT OIG hotline.
- 8** It is brokering: arranging transport by another carrier for compensation requires broker registration and \$75,000 security (49 U.S.C. 14916).
- 9** The lowest rate you'll accept: usually break-even $\times$ total miles (Module 7), lower only when the carrier agrees for a strategic reason such as a strong reload.
- 10** Open with a number backed by facts. "For 727 miles with a same-day pickup I need \$2,000. The lane has been around \$2.60 a mile."
- 11** Detention terms, lump sum paid, quick pay, stop pay, pickup window, a backhaul.
- 12** All-in total, appointments, commodity and weight, accessorials, payment terms, carrier approval, setup.

Glossary

BMC-84 — Broker's \$75,000 surety bond filing.

BMC-85 — Broker's \$75,000 trust fund filing.

BMC-36 — Notice cancelling a bond or trust.

Anchor — First number that sets the negotiation range.

Blind load — Shipment where the parties' identities are hidden; can be legitimate, but a red flag if you're asked to misrepresent yourself.

Bond claim — Carrier's claim against a broker's surety or trust for unpaid freight.

Double brokering — Re-selling a load taken as a carrier, without authority or disclosure.

Fictitious pickup — Theft where a fake carrier collects real freight.

Highway for Carriers — Free tool for carriers to verify brokers.

Identity theft — Using another company's MC/DOT or name.

Impersonation — Posing as a real broker with lookalike contacts.

L&I — FMCSA Licensing & Insurance: authority and filings.

NCCDB — FMCSA's National Consumer Complaint Database.

Phishing — Fake links or messages that steal logins.

SAFER — FMCSA company snapshot: entity type, status, contacts.

Target — The rate you aim for: target × total miles.

Walk-away — Lowest acceptable rate; usually break-even.

Unauthorized brokering — Arranging carriage without broker registration and security; unlawful.

Sources

Source	What it supports	Where
FMCSA	Broker and carrier fraud and identity theft: prevention tips and reporting channels	fmcsa.dot.gov/mission/help
FMCSA	Broker and Freight Forwarder Financial Responsibility rule: Educational and Compliance Guide (\$75,000; BMC-84/85/36; 2 business days; 7 business days; compliance 16 Jan 2026)	fmcsa.dot.gov
U.S. Code	49 U.S.C. 14916 Unlawful brokerage activities (\$10,000 per violation; joint and several liability)	govinfo.gov
Verisk CargoNet	2025 cargo theft analysis: ~\$725M losses, 2,646 incidents, \$273,990 average, theft by deception	cargonet.com
Highway	Highway for Carriers launch (18 Mar 2025, free broker verification)	highway.com
Truckstop	Freight fraud types and prevention; 13 tips for negotiating freight rates	truckstop.com/blog
CDLLife	Broker financial responsibility rule in effect (Jan 2026)	cdllife.com
User-supplied	OMNITECH manual: Ship Express rate con and Green Bay Packaging BOL (#12354); Carrier411 screen; cancelled-load photo	your files



Practice values

All brokers, domains, phone numbers, lane ranges and negotiation numbers are fictional practice values. Rules and statistics are from the sources above (checked September 2026).